

2026 Consumer Confidence Report

Report on CY 2025 Water Quality

For

Sawyer Hill Ecovillage

Berlin, Massachusetts

MassDEP PWS ID #2028017

This report is a snapshot of the drinking water quality that we provided last year. Included are details about where your water comes from, what it contains, and how it compares to state and federal standards. We are committed to providing you with this information because informed customers are our best allies.

PUBLIC WATER SYSTEM INFORMATION

Address: Village Court, Berlin, MA 01503

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Water System Improvements

Our water system is routinely inspected by the Massachusetts Department of Environmental Protection (MassDEP), who inspects this system for its technical, financial, and managerial capacity to provide safe drinking water. Your water system is operated by *Small Water Systems Services, LLC (SWSS)*, a contract drinking water and wastewater operations company, who oversee the routine operations of our system. As part of our ongoing commitment to you, last year we made the following improvements to our system:

- Discontinued temporary chlorination.

Opportunities for Public Participation

If you would like to participate in discussions regarding your water quality, you may attend the following meetings or educational events. Please contact Adam Globus-Hoenich at 857-445-2326 or email shtrustees@sawyerhill.org for more information about upcoming meetings.

YOUR DRINKING WATER SOURCE

Where Does My Drinking Water Come From?

Your water is provided by the following sources listed below:

Source Name	MassDEP Source ID#	Source Type	Location of Source
Well #1	2028017-01G	Groundwater	Northeast of the Ecovillage in the woods
Well #2	2028017-02G	Groundwater	Northeast of the Ecovillage in the woods

Is My Water Treated?

Our water system makes every effort to provide you with safe and pure drinking water. To improve the quality of the water delivered to you, we treat it to remove several contaminants. We have an emergency disinfection system installed to protect you against microbial contaminants.

The water quality of our system is constantly monitored by us and MassDEP to determine the effectiveness of existing water treatment and to determine if any additional treatment is required.

How Are These Sources Protected?

In 2001, MassDEP prepared Source Water Assessment Program (SWAP) Reports for water supply sources serving consumers at that time. The SWAP Report assesses the environmental susceptibility of public drinking water sources. Since Sawyer Hill Ecovillage was built after that date, no SWAP report is yet available. *SWSS* routinely monitors your wellhead for potential sources of contamination.

What Can Be Done to Improve Protection?

Residents can help protect sources by:

- Supporting water supply protection initiatives at the next HOA meeting.
- Taking hazardous household chemicals to hazardous material collection days.
- Limiting pesticide and fertilizer use, etc.

SUBSTANCES FOUND IN TAP WATER

Sources of drinking water (both tap water and bottled water) include rivers, lakes, streams, ponds, reservoirs, springs, and wells. As water travels over the surface of the land or through the ground, it dissolves naturally occurring minerals, and in some cases, radioactive material, and can pick up substances resulting from the presence of animals or from human activity.

Contaminants that may be present in source water include:

Microbial contaminants -such as viruses and bacteria, which may come from sewage treatment plants, septic systems, agricultural livestock operations, and wildlife.

Inorganic contaminants -such as salts and metals, which can be naturally occurring or result from urban stormwater runoff, industrial, or domestic wastewater discharges, oil and gas production, mining, and farming.

Pesticides and herbicides -which may come from a variety of sources such as agriculture, urban stormwater runoff, and residential uses.

Organic chemical contaminants -including synthetic and volatile organic chemicals, which are by-products of industrial processes and petroleum production, and can also come from gas stations, urban stormwater runoff, and septic systems.

Radioactive contaminants -which can be naturally occurring or be the result of oil and gas production and mining activities.

In order to ensure that tap water is safe to drink, the Department of Environmental Protection (MassDEP) and U.S. Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) prescribe regulations that limit the amount of certain contaminants in water provided by public water systems. The Food and Drug Administration (FDA) and Massachusetts Department of Public Health (DPH) regulations establish limits for contaminants in bottled water that must provide the same protection for public health.

All drinking water, including bottled water, may reasonably be expected to contain at least small amounts of some contaminants. The presence of contaminants does not necessarily indicate that water poses a health risk. More information about contaminants and potential health effects can be obtained by calling the EPA's Safe Drinking Water Hotline (800-426-4791).

Some people may be more vulnerable to contaminants in drinking water than the general population. Immuno-compromised persons such as persons with cancer undergoing chemotherapy, persons who have undergone organ transplants, people with HIV/AIDS or other immune system disorders, some elderly, and some infants can be particularly at risk from infections. These people should seek advice about drinking water from their health care providers. EPA/Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) guidelines on lowering the risk of infection by cryptosporidium and other microbial contaminants are available from the Safe Drinking Water Hotline (800-426-4791).

If present, elevated levels of lead can cause serious health problems, especially for pregnant women and young children. Lead in drinking water is primarily from materials and components associated with service lines and home plumbing. Sawyer Hill Ecovillage is responsible for providing high quality drinking water but cannot control the variety of materials used in plumbing components. When your water has been sitting for several hours, you can minimize the potential for lead exposure by flushing your tap for 30 seconds to 2 minutes before using water for drinking or cooking. If you are concerned about lead in your water, you may wish to have your water tested. Information on lead in drinking water, testing methods, and steps you can take to minimize exposure is available from the Safe Drinking Water Hotline or at <http://www.epa.gov/safewater/lead>.

IMPORTANT DEFINITIONS

Maximum Contaminant Level (MCL) – The highest level of a contaminant that is allowed in drinking water. MCLs are set as close to the MCLGs as feasible using the best available treatment technology.

Maximum Contaminant Level Goal (MCLG) –The level of a contaminant in drinking water below which there is no known or expected risk to health. MCLGs allow for a margin of safety.

Action Level (AL) – The concentration of a contaminant which, if exceeded, triggers treatment or other requirements that a water system must follow.

90th Percentile – Out of every 10 homes sampled, 9 were at or below this level.

Secondary Maximum Contaminant Level (SMCL) – These standards are developed to protect the aesthetic qualities of drinking water and are not health based.

Unregulated Contaminants

Unregulated contaminants are those for which EPA has not established drinking water standards. The purpose of unregulated monitoring is to assist EPA in determining their occurrence in drinking water and whether future regulation is warranted.

Bacteria	MCL / TT	MCLG	Value	Date	Violation (Y/N)	Possible Sources
Total Coliform Bacteria	MCL	0	Positive	9/22/25	N	Naturally occurring in the environment
Coliforms are bacteria that are naturally present in the environment and are used as an indicator that other, potentially harmful, waterborne pathogens may be present or that a potential pathway exists through which contamination may enter the drinking water distribution system.						

Regulated Contaminant	Date(s) Collected	Highest Result or Highest Running Average Detected	Range Detected	MCL or MRDL	MCLG or MRDLG	Violation (Y/N)	Possible Source(s) of Contamination
Inorganic Contaminants							
Barium (ppm)	2/16/21	0.009	0.007 – 0.009	2	2	N	Discharge of drilling wastes; discharge from metal refineries; erosion of natural deposits
Nitrate (ppm)	1/16/25	0.22	--	10	10	N	Runoff from fertilizer use; leaching from septic tanks; sewage; erosion of natural deposits
Radioactive Contaminants							
Gross Alpha (pCi/l) (minus uranium)	3/14/24	3.6	N/A	15	0	N	Erosion of natural deposits
Combined Radium	3/14/24	0.8	N/A	5	0	N	Erosion of natural deposits
Disinfectants and Disinfectant By-Products							
TTHM	1/16/25	1.6	--	80	N/A	N	By-product of drinking water disinfection

Unregulated and Secondary Contaminants

Unregulated contaminants are those for which there are no established drinking water standards. The purpose of unregulated contaminant monitoring is to assist regulatory agencies in determining their occurrence in drinking water and whether future regulation is warranted.

Unregulated Contaminants	Date(s) Collected	Result or Range Detected	Average Detected	SMCL	ORSG	Possible Source
Nickel (ppb)	2/16/21	ND - 3	1.5	--	100	Discharge from domestic wastewater, landfills, and mining and smelting operations
Bromodichloromethane (ppb)	1/16/25	0.8	--	--	--	Trihalomethane; by-product of drinking water chlorination
Chloroform (ppb)	1/16/25	ND	--	--	70	Trihalomethane; by-product of drinking water chlorination [In non-chlorinated sources, chloroform may be naturally occurring.]
Dibromochloromethane	1/16/25	0.8	--	--	--	Trihalomethane; by-product of drinking water chlorination
Sodium (ppm)	2/1/23	11.6	--	--	20	Discharge from the use and improper storage of sodium-containing de-icing compounds or in water-softening agents
Secondary Contaminants						
Chloride (ppm)	1/16/25	23.1	--	250	N/A	Runoff and leaching from natural deposits; seawater influence
Iron (ppb)	1/16/25	38	--	300	N/A	Natural and industrial sources as well as aging and corroding distribution systems and household pipes
Odor (T.O.N.)	1/16/25	1	--	3	N/A	Naturally occurring organic materials that form ions when in water; seawater influence

pH	1/16/25	7.10	--	6.5-8.5	N/A	Runoff and leaching from natural deposits; seawater influence
Sulfate (ppm)	1/16/25	45.9	--	250	N/A	Runoff and leaching from natural deposits; industrial wastes
Total Dissolved Solids (TDS) (ppm)	1/16/25	200	--	500	N/A	Runoff and leaching from natural deposits; seawater influence
Zinc (ppm)	1/16/25	0.211	--	5	N/A	Corrosion of household plumbing systems; erosion of natural deposits

COMPLIANCE WITH DRINKING WATER REGS

Does My Drinking Water Meet Current Health Standards?

We are committed to providing you with the best water quality available. We are proud to report that last year your drinking water met all applicable health standards regulated by the state and federal government.

HEALTH EFFECTS STATEMENTS

Lead: There is no safe level of lead in drinking water. Exposure to lead in drinking water can cause serious health effects in all age groups, especially pregnant people, infants (both formula-fed and breastfed), and young children. Some of the health effects to infants and children include decreases in IQ and attention span. Lead exposure can also result in new or worsened learning and behavior problems. The children of persons who are exposed to lead before or during pregnancy may be at increased risk of these harmful health effects. Adults have increased risks of heart disease, high blood pressure, kidney or nervous system problems. Contact your health care provider for more information about your risks.

Nickel: Some people who drink water containing nickel at high concentrations for many years could experience effects on the lung, stomach, blood, liver, kidneys, immune system, reproduction, and development.

Sodium: Sodium sensitive individuals, such as those experiencing hypertension, kidney failure, or congestive heart failure, should be aware of the sodium levels where exposures are being carefully controlled.

Total Coliform: Coliforms are bacteria that are naturally present in the environment and are used as an indicator that other, potentially harmful, waterborne pathogens may be present or that a potential pathway exists through which contamination may enter the drinking water distribution system. We found coliforms indicating the need to look for potential problems in water treatment or distribution. When this occurs, we are required to conduct assessments to identify any problems that were found during these assessments.

EDUCATIONAL INFORMATON

Cross-Connection Control and Backflow Prevention

Sawyer Hill Ecovillage makes every effort to ensure that the water delivered to your home and business is clean, safe and free of contamination. Our staff works very hard to protect the quality of the water delivered to our customers from the time the water is extracted via deep wells from underground aquifers or withdrawal point from a surface water source, throughout the entire treatment and distribution system. But what happens when the water reaches your home or business? Is there still a need to protect the water quality from contamination caused by a cross-connection? If so, how?

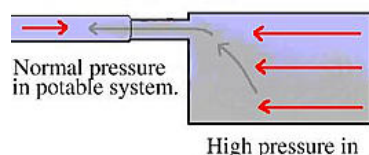
What is a cross-connection?

A cross-connection occurs whenever the drinking water supply is or could be in contact with potential sources of pollution or contamination. Cross-connections exist in piping arrangements or equipment that allows the drinking water to come in contact with non-potable liquids, solids, or gases (hazardous to humans) in event of a backflow.

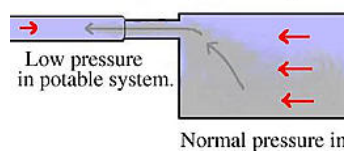
What is a backflow?

Backflow is the undesired reverse of the water flow in the drinking water distribution lines. This backward flow of water can occur when the pressure created by equipment or a system such as a boiler or air-conditioning is higher than the water pressure inside the water distribution line (back pressure), or when the pressure in the distribution line drops due to routine occurrences such as water main breaks or heavy water demand causing the water to flow backward inside the water distribution system (back siphonage). Backflow is a problem that many water consumers are unaware of, a problem that each and every water customer has a responsibility to help prevent.

Back Pressure:



Back Siphonage:



What can I do to help prevent a cross-connection?

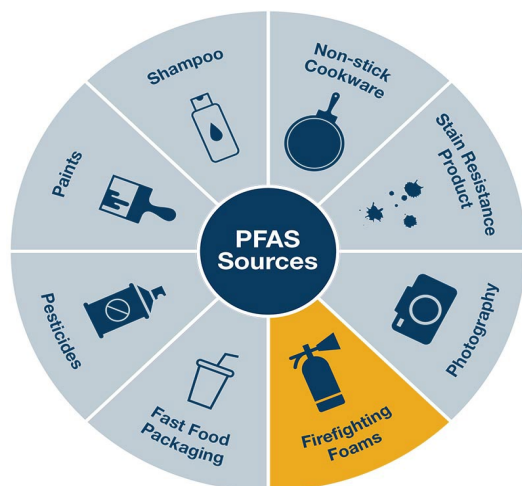
Without the proper protection something as simple as a garden hose has the potential to contaminate or pollute the drinking water lines in your house. In fact, over half of the country's cross-connection incidents involve unprotected garden hoses. There are very simple steps that you as a drinking water user can take to prevent such hazards, they are:

- NEVER submerge a hose in soapy water buckets, pet watering containers, pool, tubs, sinks, drains, or chemicals.
- NEVER attach a hose to a garden sprayer without the proper backflow preventer.
- Buy and install a hose bibb vacuum breaker in any threaded water fixture. The installation can be as easy as attaching a garden hose to a spigot. This inexpensive device is available at most hardware stores and home-improvement centers.
- Identify and be aware of potential cross-connections to your water line.
- Buy appliances and equipment with backflow preventers.
- Buy and install backflow prevention devices or assemblies for all high and moderate hazard connections.

If you are the owner or manager of a property that is being used as a commercial, industrial, or institutional facility you must have your property's plumbing system surveyed for cross-connection by your water purveyor. If your property has NOT been surveyed for cross-connection, contact your water department to schedule a cross-connection survey.

WHAT ARE PFAS AND WHY ARE THEY A PROBLEM?

Per- and polyfluoroalkyl substances (PFAS) are a family of chemicals used since the 1950s to manufacture stain-resistant, water-resistant, and non-stick products. PFAS are widely used in common consumer products such as coatings, on food packaging, outdoor clothing, carpets, leather goods, ski and snowboard waxes, and more. Certain types of firefighting foam—historically used by the U.S. military, local fire departments, and airports to fight oil and gasoline fires—may contain PFAS.



PFAS in drinking water is an important emerging issue nationwide. Because PFAS are water soluble, over time PFAS from some firefighting foam, manufacturing sites, landfills, spills, air deposition from factories and other releases can seep into surface soils. From there, PFAS can leach into groundwater or surface water, and can contaminate drinking water. PFAS have also been found in rivers, lakes, fish, and wildlife.

Exposure can occur when someone uses certain products that contain PFAS, eats PFAS-contaminated food, or drinks PFAS-contaminated water. When ingested, some PFAS can build up in the body and, over time, these PFAS may increase to a level where health effects could occur.

On October 2, 2020, MassDEP published its PFAS public drinking water standard, of 20 nanograms per liter (ng/L) (or ppt) – individually or for the sum of the concentrations of six specific PFAS. These PFAS are perfluorooctane sulfonic acid (PFOS); perfluorooctanoic acid

(PFOA); perfluorohexane sulfonic acid (PFHxS); perfluorononanoic acid (PFNA); perfluoroheptanoic acid (PFHpA); and perfluorodecanoic acid (PFDA). MassDEP abbreviates this set of six PFAS as “PFAS6.” This drinking water standard is set to be protective against adverse health effects for all people consuming the water.

For more information, see the MassDEP webpage regarding PFAS at: www.mass.gov/info-details/per-and-polyfluoroalkyl-substances-pfas, or the EPA webpage at: www.epa.gov/pfas/pfas-explained.

SWSS is working with MassDEP to ensure that all our community water systems have been and will be tested for PFAS. The results of that testing can be found in this and future Annual Water Quality Reports for your system.

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

SWSS has been contracted on an annual basis to provide licensed water operator coverage for the water system serving Sawyer Hill Ecovillage. It is our responsibility to maintain the system’s compliance with all drinking water operation requirements. We monitor your drinking water, routinely evaluate the water quality entering your distribution system and inspect the systems regularly. For more information, call your operators at *SWSS* at 978-486-1008.